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AU PAIR & ELDERLY CARE GIVING ***A Comprehensive Course***

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MODULE THREE: AFTER SURGERY CARE. INFECTIONS. WOUND CARE. NUTRITION & FOOD SAFETY.

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Develop the ability to take care of a client after surgery.
- Deal with infections.
- Assess for signs of wound infections.
- Aid with mobility and wound care.
- Understand diet requirements for recovery after surgery.



AFTER SURGERY CARE



Many elderly undergo surgery at some point for everything from hip replacements to more complex operations. Caregivers should prepare ahead of time when taking care of a senior post-surgery. They should have a conversation with their doctor to understand what the senior will need after the surgery. This may include medication or special equipment (wheelchair, compression socks, bathing chair etc.) as well as special discharge instructions and follow-up care they may need. Most of these can be arranged ahead of time by communicating with the doctor's office and having an understanding on what will be needed before the surgery happens.

1. Talk to their senior health care team

The first thing you need to do is talk to your loved one's medical team. They'll have the knowledge and expertise to shed light on the entire pre and post-surgery process. Ask them to explain in detail what your loved one will need for a successful recovery.

Medication list: Take down a list of the medication your loved one will need during their post-surgery recovery and pre-fill their prescriptions beforehand. This will ensure they have their

medication on hand when they return home. Don't forget to ask their medical care team about any over-the-counter medicine that might help with post-surgery symptoms.

Emergency contact: It's a good idea to get the contact details of your loved one's care team and make a few copies to give to other relatives or friends. Their care team should also have the contact details of immediate family or friends in case of an emergency.

Once you know what your loved one's recovery plan requires, feel free to ask anything else about enhancing their care. Questions could include:

- How long will post-surgery recovery take?
- How should your loved one care for their incision?
- How much or little physical activity should your loved one do?
- What should your loved one eat to speed up recovery?
- What behaviors should be avoided during recovery?

2. Prepare Their Living Space Ahead of Time

Keep safety in mind: After surgery, your loved one may not be able to get around their home as easily as they're used to. Look for ways to make their home as safe as possible. This could include moving their bed closer to their bathroom, taking away heavy furniture they could bump into, or making sure their medication is easily accessible.

Plan food choices ahead of time:



Surgery can be taxing on aging bodies so you'll need to make sure your loved one is well-nourished. By preparing easy-to-freeze meals ahead of time, your loved one can avoid the stress of having to cook post-surgery. Plus, by making the meals yourself, you can ensure they're nutritious and well-balanced. Don't forget water! Keeping seniors hydrated after surgery is important.

Assess their wardrobe: After surgery, your loved one won't want to feel constrained by clothing that's tight or restrictive—especially around their incisions. To ensure their comfort, look for loose clothing that won't rub or chafe when they move. The same goes for footwear. A comfortable slip-on shoe is going to make your loved one's recovery much easier than a lace-up boot.

3. Keep a Close Eye on Their Physical and Mental State

surgery can take a physical toll, especially if you're older or have existing health conditions. But the mental health challenges surgery can bring are rarely discussed. Make sure your loved one has the support they need to feel calm and in control.

Provide entertainment: This could mean replacing their usual physical activities with gentler alternatives like board games, podcasts, or even a good book. You could visit them more frequently and have longer conversations while you're there—anything you can think of to help them feel less isolated and more mentally stimulated.

Ease feelings of guilt: Sometimes people can experience feelings of guilt after a surgical procedure. Often, this is because they're not used to having to depend on someone else for their care. Try talking to your loved one and reassuring them you've chosen to help and support them after surgery. Or consider finding professional support. Caregiving services can help your loved one feel like they're not a burden to you personally, while still receiving the care they need.

4. **Make them as comfortable as possible**

For seniors, recovery from major surgery can be a slow, frustrating process. To keep them as comfortable as possible during their return home, there are a few things you can do. If they had knee, ankle, or leg surgery, their doctor may have instructed them to elevate their legs.

Be warned – although it seems simple, improperly elevating the legs can have negative effects. A leg elevation pillow helps keep their legs in a raised position that promotes healing. In addition to making them physically comfortable, don't forget to offer them emotional comfort as well. Having surgery can trigger feelings of helplessness and sadness. Grabbing a few of their favorite things – like magazines, movies, or special food items that are doctor-approved – can boost their spirits.

5. **Be Patient and Supportive**

Following surgery, your loved one may be dealing with a lot – oftentimes, their thoughts and feelings run even deeper than they may let on! Weariness, pain, exhaustion, anxiety or depression about their physical symptoms or loss of independence – all of these are commonplace after a major medical event.

As a caregiver, it's up to you to be patient, empathetic, and supportive of your loved one's wants and needs. Be willing to listen to your loved one's thoughts and concerns. In addition to helping

with housework, chores, and grooming, one of the single most important things a caregiver can do is to be present, open, and attentive. Just having an open ear and a kind smile nearby could do wonders to brighten your loved one's day, and aid in their recovery.

At the same time, it's important to help your loved one maintain or reclaim their independence over time. Be supportive, and, as your loved one regains their strength and range of motion, encourage them to take charge of their lives, as much as is realistically possible. And be present and thoughtful of your parent's needs, particularly if progress in recovery is slower than they may have hoped. In these times, having a caregiver provide solidarity and attention can do wonders for an aging adult's spirits.

6. **Be aware of hospital delirium**

Delirium is a serious change in mental abilities. It results in confused thinking and a lack of awareness of someone's surroundings. The disorder usually comes on fast — within hours or a few days. Delirium can often be traced to one or more factors. Factors may include a severe or long illness or an imbalance in the body, such as low sodium. The disorder also may be caused by certain medicines, infection, surgery, or alcohol or drug use or withdrawal.

Even if your older adult doesn't have dementia, they could become confused after surgery. Post-operation delirium is common in older adults so caregivers should be prepared in case it happens. Delirium can mean slower healing and it can be a scary experience for seniors.

If your older adult has experienced abnormal confusion in the past, it's important to let hospital staff know. And if delirium does occur, it's important to be a calm presence to support your older adult. Then, contact their doctor immediately and ask them to identify the triggering factors and recommend changes to improve the situation. Although it can take weeks or months for delirium to be fully resolved, most cases aren't life-threatening.

7. Assist with Exercises, Doctor's Visits, and Follow-Up Steps



After surgery, your loved one may be overwhelmed by the deluge of follow-up steps they have to take, including new exercises, new medication regimens, follow-up appointments, rehab or physical therapy sessions, dietary changes, and more.

To help your loved one, it might help if you assist them with scheduling, so that all of the dates and times don't become too overwhelming. You might also want to provide reminders to your loved one about when it's time to exercise, take their pills, or get ready for an appointment. At doctor's or physical therapy appointments, be sure to take notes, listen for instructions, and ask follow-up questions that your loved one may not think to ask for themselves.

8. Know their Limitations

Doing too much too soon after surgery can cause a setback in their recovery. The healing process is already slow for older bodies – the last thing you want is for them to do something that puts them back at square one. The doctor should provide information on any post-operation

restrictions. This may be difficult for some seniors to follow due to cognitive impairments or a stubbornly self-sufficient attitude.

For example, seniors who have cataract surgery should avoid bending over because it puts too much pressure on the eye. If your older adult forgets their restrictions, gently remind them of the doctor's instructions and offer to complete the task for them.

in-home caregiver can provide emotional support and a friendly, welcoming face, at a time when your loved one may need it most. At the same time, this companion can help transport your loved one to doctor's appointments, while also keeping an eye out for post-surgery complications or side effects.

INFECTION AFTER SURGERY: SIGNS & PREVENTION



Approximately 1 to 4% of people who undergo surgery will develop an infection after surgery. Infections inhibit healing and may cause additional health complications. Be alert for signs of infection after surgery. Prompt medical evaluation and treatment, if necessary, can prevent the infection from progressing. Ignoring or overlooking symptoms of infection could result in another hospital stay. According to the Agency for Healthcare Research and Quality, surgical site infections are the leading cause of hospital readmission after surgery.